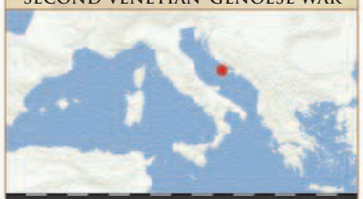
# THE BATTLE OF CURZOLA

**SECOND VENETIAN–GENOESE WAR**



**THE BATTLE OF CURZOLA**

| | |
|---|---|
| **Date** | 7 September 1298 |
| **Location** | Adriatic, off Dalmatia (Croatia) |
| **Result** | Genoese victory |

**COMBATANTS**

| VENICE | GENOA |
|---|---|

**COMMANDERS**

| | |
|---|---|
| **Andrea Dandolo**<br>**Maffeo Querini** | **Lampa Doria** |

**FORCES**

| | |
|---|---|
| **Ships:** c.100 | **Ships:** c.85 |

**LOSSES**

| | |
|---|---|
| **Men:** 7,000 killed, 7,400 taken prisoner<br>**Ships:** 18 galleys sunk, 66 captured | **Men:** c.2,000 killed<br>**Ships:** unknown |

**An indirect legacy of the battle**
It is said that Marco Polo began dictating his famous memoirs while in Genoese captivity after the battle of Curzola. He is seen here departing from Venice with his father and uncle on his journey to China.

The battle of Curzola occurred during the Second Venetian-Genoese War (1294-99). In 1298 Genoa mounted a bold raid into Venetian home waters. Sailing from La Spezia on the west coast of Italy, a fleet of Genoese galleys made its way round to the Adriatic via Tunisia and Sicily. It was commanded by the veteran Admiral Lampa Doria, younger brother of the Doria who had triumphed over the Pisans at Meloria 14 years earlier. Entering the Adriatic Doria's galleys were scattered by a storm, but most of them reassembled and proceeded up the coast of Dalmatia, burning and plundering the Venetian-ruled towns of the mainland and offshore islands. On the afternoon of 6 September they were busy pillaging the island of Curzola when a large Venetian fleet suddenly appeared on the scene.

Venice had been caught off guard by the attack on its Dalmatian possessions. A squadron of galleys commanded by Maffeo Querini was brought back from the Ionian islands and joined with freshly equipped and crewed galleys from Venice and Dalmatia to form the largest war fleet the Venetians had ever assembled. Quality had, however, been sacrificed to quantity.



**Deadly crossbow**
The principal Genoese weapon both on land and at sea was the crossbow. The highly trained Genoese crossbowmen were feared across Europe and the Middle East.

The hastily conscripted soldiers and sailors did not have the skills usually expected of Venetian galley crews. The fleet was commanded by Andrea Dandolo, son of a former Doge.

The Venetians found the Genoese galleys in a sheltered bay near the eastern tip of the island late on 6 September. Battle was joined early the following morning and lasted through to evening. It was a savage combat. The Genoese suffered heavy casualties, including Lampa Doria's son Octavian, killed by an arrow while fighting on the forecastle of his father's flagship. Seeing his men waver, the admiral had his son's body thrown unceremoniously into the sea and ordered the fight to continue. The Venetians, however, came off worse. At a crucial moment, 16 Genoese galleys that had become detached from the main body in the earlier gale returned to attack the Venetians from the flank. Only Querini's experienced crews had the skills to maneuver out of the ensuing debacle, but led back into the mêlée in an attempt to rescue Dandolo, they too were overcome.

Only a handful of galleys returned to Venice to report the disaster. Taken prisoner and bound in chains, Dandolo committed suicide by dashing his head against one of the rowing benches. Among other prisoners taken by the Genoese was Marco Polo, who had commanded one of the Venetian galleys.

The battle had little political consequence. The war ended the following year with no significant advantage to the Genoese.

